

Riccardo Di Cato

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Placement Director: Prashant Bharadwaj

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Education

University of California San Diego

2021–present

Ph.D. in Economics (expected 2027)

Research areas: Development Economics, Political Economy, and Economic History

Advisors: Sara Lowes and Samuel Bazzi (co-chairs); Paul Niehaus, Gaurav Khanna, and Craig McIntosh

University of Bologna

2018

M.Sc. in Economics, LMEC (*summa cum laude*)

University of Pavia

2016

B.A. in Economics

References

Sara Lowes (Co-chair)

Associate Professor of Economics

Department of Economics, UC San Diego

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Samuel Bazzi (Co-chair)

Professor of Economics

School of Global Policy and Strategy, UC San Diego

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Paul Niehaus

Professor of Economics

Department of Economics, UC San Diego

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Gaurav Khanna

Associate Professor of Economics

School of Global Policy and Strategy, UC San Diego

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Job Market Paper

Seeds of Market-Based Capitalism: Missionaries, Banks, and China's Modernization *with Jiachen Li*

The adoption of modern financial institutions is central to economic development. As modern banks entered nineteenth-century China, Christian missionaries expanded deep into the interior and brought foreign knowledge and skills. Beyond their effects on education and development, we show that missionaries contributed to the adoption of modern banks and shaped the recent rise of market-based capitalism in China. Before 1936, we use a staggered difference-in-differences design and find that missionary arrival increased the number of modern banks by 31% and enterprises by 27%. Newly compiled data on mission schools, publications, bankers, and elites suggest that practical education and the diffusion of knowledge contributed to the transition from traditional to modern finance. In this process, traditional banks that are substitutes for modern banks decline, while those that are more complementary survive longer. We then estimate the long-run effects of missionary exposure after 1949 using variation in the timing of railway construction relative to national missionary inflows. The historical banking advantage largely disappeared under Maoist central planning and re-emerged as markets reopened after 1978. Locations with greater historical missionary exposure have higher GDP, more enterprises, and greater foreign investment, indicating broader effects on market development. Overall, the results suggest that local skills and knowledge shape the adoption of new economic institutions, while the policy environment determines when their advantages matter.

Work in Progress

Same Faith, Different Politics: Religious Broadcasting and Voting in Italy and Spain *with Mattia Albertini*

Restricting Online Pornography and Violence Against Women: Evidence from India and the United States *with Santiago Cantillo*

Increasing Female Employment in the Automotive Sector in India *with Garima Sharma, Anant Nyshadham, and Achyuta Adhvaryu*

Religious Broadcasting and Belief Formation in Tanzania *with Mattia Albertini*

Employment

National Bureau of Economic Research 2022
Research Assistant (Prof. Samuel Bazzi)

Bocconi University 2019–2021
Research Associate (Prof. Nicola Limodio and Prof. Filippo De Marco)

Harvard University 2018–2019
Field Research Associate in the DRC (Profs. N. Nunn, J. A. Robinson, S. Lowes, and J. Weigel)

Founder and Manager, Hospitality Business 2015–2020
Established and operated three tourist residences in Italy

Presentations

Economic History Mini-Conference, UCLA Forthcoming

WEFIDEV Webinar Series in Finance and Development Forthcoming

ASREC Europe Conference, Venice 2026

Economic History Association Annual Meeting, St. Louis 2026

SIOE Conference, INSEAD 2026

HHDI–NIDE Workshop, Belfast 2026

IRES Workshop, Chapman University 2026

ASREC Conference, Chapman University 2026

ASREC Conference, George Mason University 2025

SOCAR Conference, UCLA 2025

DevPEC Conference, UC Berkeley 2025

University of Bologna WiP Seminar 2025

Migration and Development Conference, Bologna 2024

Boston University Center for the Study of Asia 2024

Teaching Experience

University of California San Diego

2021–present

Graduate: Financial Accounting; Quantitative Methods II; Quantitative Methods III

Undergraduate: Microeconomics (principles and intermediate); Financial Accounting; The Indian Economy

Bocconi University

2020

Undergraduate: Financial Markets and Institutions; Public Finance

Fellowships, Grants, and Awards

Cindy Vojtech Summer Research Prize in Economics, UC San Diego (\$1,667) 2026

IHS Research & Travel Grant (\$2,500) 2026

Summer Research Grant, UC San Diego (\$2,600) 2024–2025

Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics (\$6,885) 2023

21st Century India Center Travel Grant, UC San Diego (\$8,500) 2023

TRELS Grant, UC San Diego (\$1,000) 2022

Overseas Scholarship, Université de Montréal 2018

Erasmus Scholarship, Université Pierre Mendès France 2015

Referee Service

Journal of Development Economics; Economic Development and Cultural Change, Mission Studies

Mentoring and Community Involvement

Co-founder, Undergraduate–Graduate Economic Research Lab, UC San Diego

Co-founder and co-host, Backstory Podcast at UC San Diego

Organizer and director, church summer camp, Omegna, Italy; college-student mentor

Co-founder, “Yes, I Care” community-meeting project; volunteer with Suñu Diwaan, Senegal

Additional Information

Programming Stata, R, ArcGIS, $\LaTeX$, GeoODK (advanced); Python (intermediate); Matlab (basic)

Languages *Native:* Italian. *Fluent:* English, French. *Intermediate:* Spanish.

Citizenship Italian citizen; U.S. permanent resident; married to a Spanish-American citizen